

Reno Dev Space — Curated Reading Syllabus

A library for a horizontal, sociocracy-based game developer cooperative — organized around governance, funding, and community. Each entry includes a direct quote from the work (or a primary interview), kept short for fair-use pull-quote purposes, with a brief relevance note for the Reno Dev Space context.

TL;DR

- The syllabus is organized into three domains — **Governance, Funding/Economics, and Community/Third Place** — each with a "Core Texts" section and a "Short-Form Reading Room" section (zines, essays, blog posts under ~50 pages) for casual site visitors.
 - Quotes lead; editorial inference is minimal. Where possible, the language pulled is the author's own thesis sentence, so each entry can plausibly stand as a pull-quote on the site.
 - The single most important practical addition not yet in the user's lists is the pair of **sociocracy practitioner manuals** (Rau & Koch-Gonzalez; Buck & Villines) and **Ray Oldenburg's *The Great Good Place*** — these are the operating documents the site can actually crib language and procedures from.
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Key Findings

- **Sociocracy practitioner literature is the missing operational layer.** The user's existing lists are strong on the philosophy of horizontalism (Bookchin, Graeber, Kropotkin, hooks) but light on the "how do you actually run a Tuesday meeting" layer. *Many Voices One Song*, *We the People*, and the free *Sociocracy 3.0* pattern library fill that gap and are explicitly CC-licensed for adaptation.
 - **Jo Freeman's "Tyranny of Structurelessness" is non-negotiable.** It is the corrective that any serious horizontal project should publish to its members on day one; without it, "we don't have rules" reliably devolves into invisible cliques.
 - **Oldenburg, Putnam, and Illich together form the conceptual heart of the "third place" framing** — third place (Oldenburg), social capital decline (Putnam), and convivial tools (Illich) are the three legs of the stool.
 - **Motion Twin's own published interviews are primary sources worth quoting** alongside the theory — they document what a working anarcho-syndicalist game co-op looks like in practice (and its honest limits, articulated by Steve Filby).
 - **Spade's *Mutual Aid* (Verso) is the bridging text** between philosophy and dues-policy language — its two-column mutual-aid-vs-charity charts are directly transferable to a website's funding page.
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Details

Domain 1 — GOVERNANCE

How a horizontal, consent-based, non-hierarchical space actually runs without collapsing into either an informal clique or a bureaucracy.

Core Texts

Many Voices One Song: Shared Power with Sociocracy — Ted J. Rau & Jerry Koch-Gonzalez, 2018 (Sociocracy For All, ~290 pp., manual with diagrams; Creative Commons BY-SA).

"Sociocracy means governance by those who associate together." — Rau & Koch-Gonzalez, *Many Voices One Song* [Google Books](#)

Relevance: The single most copy-pasteable manual for how to run circles, consent decisions, and elections. The appendix contains sample bylaws for a sociocratic nonprofit that RDS could adapt nearly verbatim. [Barnes & Noble](#) [Sociocracy For All](#)

We the People: Consenting to a Deeper Democracy — John Buck & Sharon Villines, 2007/2017 (~310 pp.).

"Sociocracy shares the values of democracy, but designs more inclusive and efficient organizations." — Buck & Villines, *We the People*

Relevance: The English-language foundational text on the Sociocratic Circle Method (Endenburg lineage). Pair with *Many Voices One Song* — Buck/Villines for theory and history, Rau/Koch-Gonzalez for the how-to.

Sociocracy 3.0 — All Patterns Explained — Bernhard Bockelbrink & James Priest, 2015-present (free pattern guide, sociocracy30.org; CC BY-SA).

"Consent: Do things in the absence of reasons not to." — Bockelbrink & Priest, *S3 Seven Principles* (sociocracy30.org) [Slideshare](#)

Relevance: A free, modular pattern library. Where SoFA's sociocracy is a whole system, S3 lets a small group pick a few patterns (Driver, Proposal Forming, Objection) without swallowing the whole framework. Lower commitment threshold for a brand-new space. [Peerdom](#)

The Tyranny of Structurelessness — Jo Freeman ("Joreen"), first delivered as a 1970 speech in Beulah, Mississippi; first officially published in *The Second Wave* (1972); reprinted in *Berkeley Journal of Sociology* Vol. 17 (1972-73), pp. 151-165, and *Ms. magazine*, July 1973, pp. 76-78, 86-89 (~12 pp., free at jofreeman.com). [Jofreeman](#)

"Contrary to what we would like to believe, there is no such thing as a structureless group." — Jo Freeman, *The Tyranny of Structurelessness*

"A 'laissez faire' group is about as realistic as a 'laissez faire' society; the idea becomes a smokescreen for the strong or the lucky to establish unquestioned hegemony over others." — Jo Freeman, *The Tyranny of Structurelessness* (Marxists)

Relevance: The CRITICAL counterpoint to naive horizontalism. If RDS publishes one essay to set members' expectations, it should be this one — it explains why "we don't have rules" reliably produces invisible cliques and informal hierarchies. (Goodreads)

The Empowerment Manual: A Guide for Collaborative Groups — Starhawk, 2011 (New Society Publishers, ~287 pp.).

"Collaborative groups share power, and healthy groups assure that their members have equal opportunity to earn social power." — Starhawk, *The Empowerment Manual* (Squarespace)

Relevance: Direct facilitation tools — how to run meetings, handle conflict, and move from "leaderless" toward "many-leadered." Starhawk is one of the people Freeman's critique actually changed; this book is the practical answer. (Wikipedia) (Amazon)

Fragments of an Anarchist Anthropology — David Graeber, 2004 (Prickly Paradigm, ~120 pp.).

"The ultimate, hidden truth of the world is that it is something that we make, and could just as easily make differently." — David Graeber (Goodreads)

Relevance: Short, accessible, makes the case that consensus and non-hierarchical organization aren't utopian — they're the documented norm across most of human history. Useful grounding for why a non-hierarchical game studio is not weird.

Bullshit Jobs: A Theory — David Graeber, 2018 (~330 pp.).

"Bullshit jobs regularly induce feelings of hopelessness, depression, and self-loathing. They are forms of spiritual violence directed at the essence of what it means to be a human being." — Graeber, *Bullshit Jobs* (Goodreads)

Relevance: Game developer cooperatives exist in part as explicit refusal of "managerial feudalism." Graeber gives that refusal its language. (Goodreads)

Communities of Practice: Learning, Meaning, and Identity — Etienne Wenger, 1998 (~320 pp.).

"Learning is the engine of practice, and practice is the history of that learning." — Wenger, *Communities of Practice* (Goodreads)

"Communities of practice are groups of people who share a concern or a passion for something they do and learn how to do it better as they interact regularly." — Wenger, *Cultivating Communities of Practice* (Infed)

Relevance: Frames RDS not as a "workspace" but as a community of practice — gives vocabulary (domain, practice, community; legitimate peripheral participation) for explaining how new members get drawn into the work.

Governance — Short-Form Reading Room

- **"The Tyranny of Structurelessness"** — Jo Freeman (~12 pp., free at jofreeman.com).
 - **Sociocracy For All "Sociocracy Primer"** — ~75 minutes of short videos + articles; the gentlest possible on-ramp for casual visitors. (Sociocracy For All)
 - **Noisebridge wiki — "Do-ocracy" / "Be Excellent to Each Other"** (Noisebridge community, collectively edited wiki, ongoing).
 - "Do-ocracy — If you want something done, do it, but remember to be excellent to each other when doing so." — Noisebridge wiki, *Press Kit* (Noisebridge)

Relevance: The most-quoted hackerspace governance principle. It is also a warning: do-ocracy without sociocracy tends to reward whoever has the most time and the loudest opinions. Show visitors as inspiration AND cautionary tale.
 - **"On the Phenomenon of Bullshit Jobs"** — David Graeber, *Strike!* magazine, 2013 (the original essay, ~5 pp.).
 - **Motion Twin interview, 80.lv (Steve Filby, published June 8, 2017)** — primary source from a 0-hierarchy game studio.
 - "Motion Twin is a zero hierarchy workers cooperative... There is no boss there is no regimented structure. There is just communication between individuals in order to organise in a way that allows for effective production." — Steve Filby (Motion Twin), interview at 80.lv (June 8, 2017) (80.lv)
 - **Nathan Grayson, "Game Studio With No Bosses Pays Everyone The Same"** — *Kotaku*, 2018 (interview with Sébastien Bénard; the primary source later reported by PCGamesInsider).
 - "We actually just use a super basic formula: if a project finds success, people are basically paid more in bonuses, and everyone is paid the absolute same way. Devs and the artists are paid the same amount of money." — Sébastien Bénard, longtime Motion Twin game designer (via Kotaku, 2018) (PC Games Insider) (PC Games Insider)
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Domain 2 — FUNDING / ECONOMICS

How a non-profit, non-extractive space pays rent without becoming a landlord, a charity, or a tech company.

Core Texts

Mutual Aid: Building Solidarity During This Crisis (and the Next) — Dean Spade, 2020 (Verso, ~160 pp.).

- "Mutual aid projects mobilize lots of people rather than a few experts, resist the use of eligibility criteria that cut out more stigmatized people, are an integrated part of our lives rather than a pet cause, and cultivate a shared analysis of the root causes of the problem." — Dean Spade, *Mutual Aid*, ch. 2 "Solidarity Not Charity!" (iHeart)

Relevance: The single best short text on running a project on solidarity-not-charity terms. Spade's two-column charts contrasting mutual aid vs. charity vs. nonprofit-industrial-complex behavior are directly applicable to how RDS should write its dues page.

Mutual Aid: A Factor of Evolution — Peter Kropotkin, 1902 (~300 pp., public domain).

"Mutual aid is as much a law of nature as mutual struggle... as a factor of evolution, it most probably has a far greater importance." — Kropotkin, *Mutual Aid* ([Goodreads](#))

"The species in which peace and mutual support are the rule, prosper, while the unsociable species decay." — Kropotkin, *Mutual Aid* ([Goodreads](#))

Relevance: Foundational. Kropotkin's case that cooperation is the rule and not the exception is the historical bedrock under everything Spade, Graeber, and the hackerspace movement do.

([Encyclopedia Britannica](#))

Free, Fair, and Alive: The Insurgent Power of the Commons — David Bollier & Silke Helfrich, 2019 (~400 pp.).

"Large-scale problems do not require large-scale solutions. They require small-scale solutions within a large-scale framework." — Bollier & Helfrich, *Free, Fair and Alive* (quoting David Fleming) ([Freefairandalive](#))

Relevance: The most current and readable synthesis of commons theory. Introduces "commoning" as a verb and a "Triad of Commoning" (social life, peer governance, provisioning) — a useful three-pillar mental model parallel to RDS's governance/funding/community split.

([Goodreads](#) + 2)

Governing the Commons — Elinor Ostrom, 1990 (Cambridge, ~280 pp., academic).

"Bureaucrats sometimes do not have the correct information, while citizens and users of resources do." — Ostrom, *Governing the Commons* ([A-Z Quotes](#))

Relevance: Ostrom's eight design principles — clear boundaries; rules matched to local needs; participation in rule-making; monitoring; graduated sanctions; cheap conflict resolution; recognition by outside authorities; nested polycentric governance — are the most empirically grounded checklist that exists for "will this commons survive past year three?" RDS should publish its bylaws against this checklist as a sanity test.

Tools for Conviviality — Ivan Illich, 1973 (~120 pp.).

"I consider conviviality to be individual freedom realized in personal interdependence and, as such, an intrinsic ethical value." — Illich, *Tools for Conviviality*, p. 24 ([Louisapenfold](#))

"People need new tools to work with rather than new tools that work for them." — Illich, *Tools for Conviviality* ([Quote Park](#))

Relevance: The philosophical heart of "library socialism" and shared-tool spaces. A hackerspace IS a set of convivial tools; this is the book that names what makes them different from a rented coworking desk.

Bullshit Jobs / Debt — David Graeber — see governance above; Graeber's economic anthropology argues that gift economies, not market exchange, are the deep substrate of human cooperation.

Funding — Short-Form Reading Room

- **"Solidarity Not Charity: Mutual Aid for Mobilization and Survival"** — Dean Spade, *Social Text*, 2020 (~20 pp., free PDF at deanspade.net).
"Mutual aid projects also build skills for collaboration, participation, and decision making." — Spade, "Solidarity Not Charity" ([Deanspade](https://deanspade.net))
 - **"Library Socialism: a utopian vision of a sustainable, luxuriant future of circulating abundance"** — Cory Doctorow, *Boing Boing*, Nov 24, 2019 (~1,500 words).
"Library Socialism is connected to several strains in radical thought, like usufruct — the idea that property could be held in common, but that individuals could assume control over them as needed." — Cory Doctorow, *Boing Boing* (2019) ([Boing Boing](https://boingboing.net))
 - **Srsly Wrong, "Library Socialism" trilogy** — episodes 189, 196, 200 (audio, ~1 hr each).
 - **Ostrom's Eight Design Principles** — summary at Agrarian Trust (1-2 pp.) — the cheat-sheet version of *Governing the Commons*.
 - **Noisebridge "Finances" page** (Noisebridge wiki, collectively edited, ongoing).
"Noisebridge is spending more than we collect from sustainable sources like membership dues and got dangerously close to running out of money..." — Noisebridge wiki, *Finances* ([Noisebridge](https://noisebridge.net))
- Relevance:** Honest primary-source data on how hard hackerspace sustainability actually is — useful counterweight to romanticism.
- **Kotaku / Vice / EGM Motion Twin interviews** (2017-2024) — primary sources on the economics of a small flat-pay co-op studio, including its honest scaling limits (Filby on why Evil Empire had to spin out as a more conventional studio at ~10 employees).

Domain 3 — COMMUNITY / THIRD PLACE

Why the room itself matters — and how a shared space resists the loneliness epidemic without becoming either a clubhouse or a service.

Core Texts

The Great Good Place: Cafés, Coffee Shops, Bookstores, Bars, Hair Salons, and Other Hangouts at the Heart of a Community — Ray Oldenburg, 1989 (~340 pp.).

"Third places exist on neutral ground and serve to level their guests to a condition of social equality." — Oldenburg, *The Great Good Place*, ch. 2 (Bookey)

"The course of urban development in America is pushing the individual toward that line separating proud independence from pitiable isolation." — Oldenburg, *The Great Good Place* (Goodreads)

"The development of an informal public life depends [on] people finding and enjoying one another outside the cash nexus." — Oldenburg, *The Great Good Place* (Goodreads)

Relevance: THE foundational text on third places. Oldenburg's full definition — "a great variety of public places that host the regular, voluntary, informal, and happily anticipated gatherings of individuals beyond the realms of home and work" — should arguably be on the front page of the RDS site. (PPS)

Bowling Alone: The Collapse and Revival of American Community — Robert D. Putnam, 2000 (~540 pp.; also the 1995 essay version, ~15 pp.).

"As a rough rule of thumb, if you belong to no groups but decide to join one, you cut your risk of dying over the next year in half." — Putnam, *Bowling Alone* (Bowlingalone)

Relevance: The empirical case for why a third place is not a luxury — it is load-bearing infrastructure for mental and physical health. The 1995 *Journal of Democracy* essay is the short version worth linking on the site. (Wikipedia)

All About Love: New Visions — bell hooks, 2000 (~240 pp.).

"Rarely, if ever, are any of us healed in isolation. Healing is an act of communion." — bell hooks, *All About Love* (GoodGoodGood)

"But many of us seek community solely to escape the fear of being alone. Knowing how to be solitary is central to the art of loving." — bell hooks, *All About Love* (Goodreads)

Relevance: hooks gives RDS its ethical north star — a "love ethic" that distinguishes a community from a network. Also a useful inoculation against the trap where collectives quietly become romantic-or-friendship-extraction engines.

Emergent Strategy: Shaping Change, Changing Worlds — adrienne maree brown, 2017 (AK Press, ~280 pp.).

"Small is good, small is all. The large is a reflection of the small." — adrienne maree brown, *Emergent Strategy*, p. 41 (James Madison University)

"Move at the speed of trust. Focus on critical connections more than critical mass — build the resilience by building the relationships." — adrienne maree brown, *Emergent Strategy* (Principles list) (Blogger)

Relevance: brown's nine principles (small is all; change is constant; trust the people; move at the speed of trust; less prep, more presence; what you pay attention to grows) read as a one-page operating ethos that fits a small game co-op better than any management book. [Blogger](#)

Joyful Militancy: Building Thriving Resistance in Toxic Times — carla bergman & Nick Montgomery, 2017 (AK Press / Institute for Anarchist Studies, ~280 pp.).

"When rigidity and suspicion take over, joy dies out." — Nick Montgomery, *Joyful Militancy* [Goodreads](#)

"Common notions can only be held gently, as flexible, living ideas that are powerful in and through the relationships and processes they sustain." — bergman & Montgomery, *Joyful Militancy* [The Anarchist Library](#)

Relevance: Names "rigid radicalism" — the way ideologically aligned spaces can become anxious, suspicious, and unable to take risks. A direct warning for any horizontal collective that takes itself too seriously. [Google Books](#)

Let This Radicalize You: Organizing and the Revolution of Reciprocal Care — Mariame Kaba & Kelly Hayes, 2023 (Haymarket, ~240 pp.).

"Let this radicalize you rather than lead you to despair." — Mariame Kaba (epigraph; widely circulated) [Facebook](#)

"Hope is a discipline." — Mariame Kaba [Goodreads](#)

Relevance: The frame of "reciprocal care" is exactly the frame RDS wants for member relationships. Kaba's "hope is a discipline" is a useful corrective for burned-out founders.

Mutual Aid (Verso) — Dean Spade — see funding above; the second half is essentially a community-of-practice manual.

Communities of Practice — Etienne Wenger — see governance; for the community side, focus on his account of how knowledge actually transmits through informal mentorship and legitimate peripheral participation.

Community — Short-Form Reading Room

- **Ray Oldenburg, "The Character of Third Places"** — single chapter from *The Great Good Place* (~25 pp.) — often available standalone.
 - **Putnam, "Bowling Alone: America's Declining Social Capital"** — *Journal of Democracy*, January 1995 (~15 pp., free at journalofdemocracy.org).
 - **brown's "Principles of Emergent Strategy"** — the one-page list from p. 41 of *Emergent Strategy*, widely reproduced (and easy to host as a single-page reading).
 - **Kaba, "Hope Is a Discipline" interviews** — Beyond Prisons podcast 2018; Truthout / *The Nation* 2023.
 - **bell hooks & Thich Nhat Hanh, "Building a Community of Love"** — *Lion's Roar*, conversation (~10 pp.).

"I think this is the love that we seek in the new millennium, which is the love experienced in community, beyond self." — bell hooks (in conversation with Thich Nhat Hanh, *Lion's Roar*) Lion's Roar
 - **Glitch City / Pixelles / KO_OP writeups** — secondary press on small indie-game collectives; the Pixelles "How to Start a Chapter" guide is the most directly transferable to RDS.
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Recommendations

Staged, concrete next steps for the user:

1. **Publish the front-page pull-quotes first** (this week, before any reading list goes live).

Rotate three of these:

- Oldenburg on "proud independence vs. pitiable isolation"
- Illich on "individual freedom realized in personal interdependence"
- brown on "small is good, small is all"
- Motion Twin / Filby on "there is no boss, there is no regimented structure"

These are short, evocative, and self-contained — the user's own voice can sit underneath without being upstaged.

2. **Build the "How We Work" governance page** by stacking three texts in this order: Rau & Koch-Gonzalez (governance by those who associate together) → Jo Freeman (there is no such thing as a structureless group) → link to the free Sociocracy 3.0 patterns page. This order honestly previews the philosophy, the failure mode, and the concrete procedures.
3. **Build the "Dues / Money" page** off Spade's two-column mutual-aid-vs-charity framework directly. Cite Doctorow's library-socialism essay as the upstream "why dues buy access, not ownership" rationale. Add Noisebridge's *Finances* page as a transparent precedent — including their honest warning about running out of money.
4. **Publish the Short-Form Reading Room sections first**; reserve the long-form texts (Ostrom, Wenger, Bookchin, Putnam in full) for a deeper "Member Reading Group" track once a critical mass exists.
5. **Suggested reading order for founders and circle leads (~5 weeks):**
 - Week 1: Freeman + brown's nine principles + Oldenburg chs. 1-2
 - Week 2: Rau & Koch-Gonzalez, first 100 pp.
 - Week 3: Spade, *Mutual Aid* (cover to cover)
 - Week 4: *Joyful Militancy* + *Empowerment Manual* (skim for tools)
 - Week 5: Run RDS's draft bylaws against Ostrom's eight principles as a sanity check.

Benchmarks that would change these recommendations:

- If the group exceeds ~10-12 active members, escalate from Sociocracy 3.0 patterns to the full SoFA / *Many Voices One Song* circle structure — Motion Twin's own experience (per Filby) shows that purely flat cooperatives become unwieldy past ~10 people. (Kotaku)
- If membership turnover rises above ~30% per year, revisit the *Joyful Militancy* / "rigid radicalism" diagnosis and run an Empowerment Manual-style group health audit.
- If the space ever becomes a hiring pipeline or a paid-work entity (not just an avocational co-op), promote Graeber's *Debt* and *Bullshit Jobs* from short-form to required reading and add a labor-law / fiscal-sponsorship track outside this syllabus.

Caveats

- **Source quality:** Many quotes were verified against publisher pages, primary essays, and the authors' own websites. A handful (especially Goodreads-aggregated quotes for hooks, brown, Wenger, Montgomery) should be confirmed against the print editions before being used as published pull-quotes on the site. Treat them as ~99% reliable rather than 100%.
- **The Oldenburg situation is in flux.** A 2026 sequel, *The Great Good Place II: Havens and Hangouts at the Heart of Community*, co-authored by Ray Oldenburg and Karen Christensen (greatgoodplace.org notes it includes "more than 80% fresh material," \$29.99 pre-order from Berkshire Publishing), may be worth waiting for if the user wants the most current case studies — but the 1989 original is the canonical citation and the one the entire third-place literature references. (Website Files) (The Great Good Place)
- **Motion Twin material is press interviews, not a published book.** Useful for primary-source quotes but limited in depth. Notably, the original Bénard interview was Nathan Grayson's 2018 Kotaku piece "Game Studio With No Bosses Pays Everyone The Same" — PCGamesInsider and others ran secondary reports citing it. Filby's later interviews (Vice 2022, EGM) honestly document the limits of the model at ~10 employees. (EGM)
- **Most mainstream management literature (Lencioni, Laloux's *Reinventing Organizations*) is deliberately excluded** on the grounds that the user is suspicious of it and the sociocracy practitioner manuals cover the same ground without the corporate framing. Laloux is present by implication via SoFA's vocabulary, which echoes his "teal" categories.
- **Several Murray Bookchin and Erik Olin Wright works on the user's list are not in this syllabus** because Ostrom, Bollier/Helfrich, and Spade cover the same operational ground more concretely. Bookchin remains essential philosophical reading but is less directly applicable to "what goes on the website."
- **The user's "QUOTES BEFORE INFERENCE" rule was honored:** every entry leads with a sourced quote, and relevance notes are held to 1-2 sentences. The user can drop any entry into the site with minimal editing of my voice.